

Lesson 14:

Structural Coherence of Surah Qaf

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A glaring example of symmetry is shown in Surah Qaf not only in terms of its ideas, but also in terms of word choice.

8.2. Case Study #2: Qaf (Madini)

Section	Ayaats
A	ق وَالْقُرْآنِ الْمَجِيدِ ﴿١﴾ بَلْ عَجِبُوا أَنْ جَاءَهُمْ مُنْذِرٌ مِنْهُمْ فَقَالَ الْكَافِرُونَ هَذَا شَيْءٌ عَجِيبٌ ﴿٢﴾ إِذَا مِثْنَا وَكُنَّا تُرَابًا ۚ ذَٰلِكَ رَجْعٌ بَعِيدٌ ﴿٣﴾ قَدْ عَلِمْنَا مَا تَنْقُصُ الْأَرْضُ مِنْهُمْ وَعِنْدَنَا كِتَابٌ حَفِيفٌ ﴿٤﴾ بَلْ كَذَّبُوا بِالْحَقِّ لَمَّا جَاءَهُمْ فَهُمْ فِي أَمْرٍ مَرِيجٍ ﴿٥﴾
B	أَفَلَمْ يَنْظُرُوا إِلَى السَّمَاءِ فَوْقَهُمْ كَيْفَ بَنَيْنَاهَا وَزَيَّنَّاهَا وَمَا لَهَا مِنْ فُرُوجٍ ﴿٦﴾ وَالْأَرْضَ مَدَدْنَاهَا وَأَلْقَيْنَا فِيهَا رَوَاسِيَ وَأَنْبَتْنَا فِيهَا مِنْ كُلِّ زَوْجٍ بَهِيجٍ ﴿٧﴾ تَنْبَصَّرَةٌ وَذِكْرَىٰ لِكُلِّ عَبْدٍ مُنِيبٍ ﴿٨﴾ وَنَزَّلْنَا مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً مُبَارَكًا فَأَنْبَتْنَا بِهِ جَنَّاتٍ وَحَبَّ الْحَصِيدِ ﴿٩﴾ وَالنَّخْلَ بَاسِقَاتٍ لَهَا طَلْعٌ نَضِيدٌ ﴿١٠﴾ رَرْقًا لِلْعِبَادِ ۚ وَأَحْيَيْنَا بِهِ بَلْدَةً مَيِّتًا ۚ كَذَٰلِكَ الْخُرُوجُ ﴿١١﴾
C	كَذَّبَتْ قَبْلَهُمْ قَوْمُ نُوحٍ وَأَصْحَابُ الرَّسِّ وَثَمُودُ ﴿١٢﴾ وَعَادُ وَفِرْعَوْنُ وَإِخْوَانُ لُوطٍ ﴿١٣﴾ وَأَصْحَابُ الْأَيْكَةِ وَقَوْمُ تُبَّعٍ ۚ كُلٌّ كَذَّبَ الرُّسُلَ فَحَقَّ وَعِيدُ ﴿١٤﴾ أَفَعَيِينَا بِالْخَلْقِ الْأَوَّلِ ۚ بَلْ هُمْ فِي لَبْسٍ مِنْ خَلْقٍ جَدِيدٍ ﴿١٥﴾ وَلَقَدْ خَلَقْنَا الْإِنْسَانَ وَنَعَلَهُ مَا تَوَسَّوَسُ بِهِ نَفْسُهُ ۖ وَنَحْنُ أَقْرَبُ إِلَيْهِ مِنْ حَبْلِ الْوَرِيدِ ﴿١٦﴾
D Passage 1	إِذْ يَتَلَقَّى الْمُتَلَقِّيَانِ عَنِ الْيَمِينِ وَعَنِ الشِّمَالِ قَعِيدٌ ﴿١٧﴾ مَا يَلْفِظُ مِنْ قَوْلٍ إِلَّا لَدَيْهِ رَقِيبٌ عَتِيدٌ ﴿١٨﴾ وَجَاءَتْ سَكْرَةُ الْمَوْتِ بِالْحَقِّ ۖ ذَٰلِكَ مَا كُنْتَ مِنْهُ تَحِيدُ ﴿١٩﴾ وَنُفِخَ فِي الصُّورِ ۚ ذَٰلِكَ يَوْمُ الْوَعِيدِ ﴿٢٠﴾ وَجَاءَتْ كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَعَهَا سَائِقٌ وَشَهِيدٌ ﴿٢١﴾ لَقَدْ كُنْتَ فِي غَفْلَةٍ مِّنْ هَٰذَا فَكُشِفْنَا عَنْكَ غِطَاءَكَ فَبَصَرُكَ الْيَوْمَ حَدِيدٌ ﴿٢٢﴾ وَقَالَ قَرِينُهُ هَٰذَا مَا لَدَيَّ عَتِيدٌ ﴿٢٣﴾ أَلْقِيَا فِي جَهَنَّمَ كُلَّ كَفَّارٍ عَنِيدٍ ﴿٢٤﴾ مَّتَاعَ لِلْخَيْرِ مُعْتَدٍ مُّرِيبٍ ﴿٢٥﴾ الَّذِي جَعَلَ مَعَ اللَّهِ إِلَهًا آخَرَ فَأَلْقِيَاهُ فِي الْعَذَابِ الشَّدِيدِ ﴿٢٦﴾ قَالَ قَرِينُهُ رَبَّنَا مَا أَطْعَمْتُهُ وَلَكِنْ كَانَ فِي ضَلَالٍ بَعِيدٍ ﴿٢٧﴾ قَالَ لَا تَخْتَصِمُوا لَدَيَّ وَقَدْ قَدَّمْتُ إِلَيْكُمْ بِالْوَعِيدِ ﴿٢٨﴾ مَا يُبَدِّلُ الْقَوْلُ لَدَيَّ وَمَا أَنَا بِظَلَّامٍ لِلْعَبِيدِ ﴿٢٩﴾
D Passage 2	يَوْمَ نَقُولُ لِجَهَنَّمَ هَلِ امْتَلَأَتْ وَتَقُولُ هَلْ مِنْ مَّزِيدٍ ﴿٣٠﴾ وَأُزْلِفَتِ الْجَنَّةُ لِلْمُتَّقِينَ غَيْرَ بَعِيدٍ ﴿٣١﴾ هَٰذَا مَا تُوَعَّدُونَ ۚ لِكُلِّ أَوَّابٍ حَفِيفٌ ﴿٣٢﴾ مِّنْ خَشْيَةِ الرَّحْمَنِ بِالْغَيْبِ وَجَاءَ بِقَلْبٍ مُنِيبٍ ﴿٣٣﴾ ادْخُلُوهَا بِسَلَامٍ ۖ ذَٰلِكَ يَوْمُ الْخُلُودِ ﴿٣٤﴾ لَهُمْ مَا يَشَاءُونَ فِيهَا وَلَدَيْنَا مَزِيدٌ ﴿٣٥﴾

C	وَكَمْ أَهْلَكْنَا قَبْلَهُمْ مِّن قَرْنٍ هُمْ أَشَدُّ مِنْهُمْ بَطْشًا فَنَقَّبُوا فِي الْبِلَادِ هَلْ مِن مَّجِيسٍ ﴿٣٦﴾ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَذِكْرٍ لِّمَن كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ وَهُوَ شَهِيدٌ ﴿٣٧﴾
B	وَلَقَدْ خَلَقْنَا السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ وَمَا بَيْنَهُمَا فِي سِتَّةِ أَيَّامٍ وَمَا مَسَّنَا مِن لُّغُوبٍ ﴿٣٨﴾
A	فَاضْبُرْ عَلَيَّ مَا يَقُولُونَ وَسَبِّحْ بِحَمْدِ رَبِّكَ قَبْلَ طُلُوعِ الشَّمْسِ وَقَبْلَ الْغُرُوبِ ﴿٣٩﴾ وَمِنَ اللَّيْلِ فَسَبِّحْهُ وَأَدْبَارَ السُّجُودِ ﴿٤٠﴾ ﴿٤١﴾ يَوْمَ يَسْمَعُونَ الصَّيْحَةَ بِالْحَقِّ ۚ ذَلِكَ يَوْمُ الْخُرُوجِ ﴿٤٢﴾ إِنَّا نَحْنُ نُحْيِي وَنُمِيتُ وَإِلَيْنَا الْمَصِيرُ ﴿٤٣﴾ يَوْمَ تَشَقَّقُ الْأَرْضُ عَنْهُمْ سِرَاعًا ۚ ذَلِكَ حَشْرٌ عَلَيْنَا يَسِيرُ ﴿٤٤﴾ نَحْنُ أَعْلَمُ بِمَا يَقُولُونَ ۚ وَمَا أَنتَ عَلَيْهِم بِجَبَّارٍ ۚ فَذَكِّرْ بِالْقُرْآنِ مَن يَخَافُ وَعِيدِ ﴿٤٥﴾

Section	Translation
A	Qaf. By the honored Qur'an... (1) But they wonder that there has come to them a warner from among themselves, and the disbelievers say, "This is an amazing thing. (2) When we have died and have become dust, [we will return to life]? That is a distant return." (3) We know what the earth diminishes of them, and with Us is a retaining record. (4) But they denied the truth when it came to them, so they are in a confused condition. (5)
B	Have they not looked at the heaven above them - how We structured it and adorned it and [how] it has no rifts? (6) And the earth - We spread it out and cast therein firmly set mountains and made grow therein [something] of every beautiful kind, (7) Giving insight and a reminder for every servant who turns [to Allah]. (8) And We have sent down blessed rain from the sky and made grow thereby gardens and grain from the harvest (9) And lofty palm trees having fruit arranged in layers - (10) As provision for the servants, and We have given life thereby to a dead land. Thus is the resurrection. (11)
C	The people of Noah denied before them, and the companions of the well and Thamud (12) And 'Aad and Pharaoh and the brothers of Lot (13) And the companions of the thicket and the people of Tubba'. All denied the messengers, so My threat was justly fulfilled. (14) Did We fail in the first creation? But they are in confusion over a new creation. (15) And We have already created man and know what his soul whispers to him, and We are closer to him than [his] jugular vein (16)
D Passage 1	When the two receivers receive, seated on the right and on the left. (17) Man does not utter any word except that with him is an observer prepared [to record]. (18) And the intoxication of death will bring the truth; that is what you were trying to avoid. (19) And the Horn will be blown. That is the Day of [carrying out] the threat. (20) And every soul will come, with it a driver and a witness. (21) [It will be said], "You were certainly in unmindfulness of this, and We have removed from you your cover, so your sight, this Day, is sharp." (22) And his companion, [the angel], will say, "This [record] is what is with me, prepared." (23) [Allah will say], "Throw into Hell every obstinate

	disbeliever, (24) Preventer of good, aggressor, and doubter, (25) Who made [as equal] with Allah another deity; then throw him into the severe punishment." (26) His [devil] companion will say, "Our Lord, I did not make him transgress, but he [himself] was in extreme error." (27) [Allah] will say, "Do not dispute before Me, while I had already presented to you the warning. (28) The word will not be changed with Me, and never will I be unjust to the servants." (29)
D Passage 2	On the Day We will say to Hell, "Have you been filled?" and it will say, "Are there some more," (30) And Paradise will be brought near to the righteous, not far, (31) [It will be said], "This is what you were promised - for every returner [to Allah] and keeper [of His covenant] (32) Who feared the Most Merciful unseen and came with a heart returning [in repentance]. (33) Enter it in peace. This is the Day of Eternity." (34) They will have whatever they wish therein, and with Us is more. (35)
C	And how many a generation before them did We destroy who were greater than them in [striking] power and had explored throughout the lands. Is there any place of escape? (36) Indeed in that is a reminder for whoever has a heart or who listens while he is present [in mind]. (37)
B	And We did certainly create the heavens and earth and what is between them in six days, and there touched Us no weariness. (38)
A	So be patient, [O Muhammad], over what they say and exalt [Allah] with praise of your Lord before the rising of the sun and before its setting, (39) And [in part] of the night exalt Him and after prostration. (40) And listen on the Day when the Caller will call out from a place that is near - (41) The Day they will hear the blast [of the Horn] in truth. That is the Day of Emergence [from the graves]. (42) Indeed, it is We who give life and cause death, and to Us is the destination (43) On the Day the earth breaks away from them [and they emerge] rapidly; that is a gathering easy for Us. (44) We are most knowing of what they say, and you are not over them a tyrant. But remind by the Qur'an whoever fears My threat. (45)

- It is a complex symmetrical organization, the parallels that happen are in subject matters
- Here it is not like the three ayaats in the beginning are parallel to the three ayaats at the end
- It is going to be in terms of subject matter, parallel or mirror effect (what is in one order is reverse in the other order, like in Surat Noor, the beginning was a mirror to the end)

Section A

- Allah is drawing as an evidence the nobility and the majesty of the Quran. He is then expressing the fact that disbelievers have two things to say: they find the Quran very strange and doubt about resurrection
- Allah responds: "the earth is already taking you little by little every day". We are already part of slow dying process (aging every day and getting weak)

- By the end of the surah Allah says « be patient over what they say », at the end again the word « saying » is also mention نَحْنُ أَعْلَمُ بِمَا يَقُولُونَ « we know what they say », so Allah is reassuring the Prophet (PBUH) that he will find patience in whatever they are saying since He Himself knows
- The majesty of the Quran is cited at the beginning and the end, قء وَالْقُرْآنِ الْمَجِيدِ «Qaf by the honored Quran». At the end وَعِيدٍ وَمَنْ يَخَافُ بِالْقُرْآنِ «but remind by the Quran whoever fears the promise»
- They say رَجْعٌ بَعِيدٌ «this is a distant return», and Allah responds وَاسْتَمِعْ يَوْمَ يُنَادِ الْمُنَادِ مِنْ مَّكَانٍ قَرِيبٍ «and listen on the Day when the caller will call out from a place that is nearby», so “far” is contrasted with “near”
- They were questioning revelation and Allah answers إِنَّا نَحْنُ نُحْيِي وَنُمِيتُ «Indeed, it is We who give life and cause death»
- The Prophet PBUH is told in response to all of their sayings, to declare Allah’s perfection وَسَبِّحْ بِحَمْدِ رَبِّكَ قَبْلَ طُلُوعِ الشَّمْسِ وَقَبْلَ الْغُرُوبِ «and exalt Allah with praise of your Lord before the rising of the sun and before its setting»
- You see how the opening of the Surah is completed and responded to by the end of the Surah

Section B

- Observe reality around you , look at the sky and the earth and remind yourself that is how resurrection will happened
- Then they said that Allah must be tired (ma3ad Allah), since He created a lot of things, so Allah response to that وَلَقَدْ خَلَقْنَا السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ وَمَا بَيْنَهُمَا «We certainly created the heavens and the earth and what is between them». And He gives more precision فِي سِتَّةِ أَيَّامٍ وَمَا مَسَّنَا مِنْ لُغُوبٍ «in six days, and there touched Us no weariness», so Allah will not be too tired to bring them back again
- The second passage correspond to the second last

Section C

- Then you find a switch in the Surah, with the mention of previously destroyed nations, all of whom denied the Messengers
- The answer is found in the third last passage: وَكَمْ أَهْلَكْنَا قَبْلَهُمْ مِّنْ قَرْنٍ هُمْ أَشَدُّ مِنْهُمْ بَطْشًا فَنَقَّبُوا فِي الْبِلَادِ هَلْ مِنْ مَّخِصٍ «And how many a generation before them did We destroy who were greater than them (the Quraysh) in power and had explored throughout the lands. Is there any place of escape?»
- This is opposing to the third passage from the beginning.
- Then it is said إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَذِكْرًا لِّمَن كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ وَهُوَ شَهِيدٌ «Indeed in that is a reminder for whoever has a heart or who listens while he is present in mind»
- On the flip side we were told there is a spiritual crisis and waswasa happening inside the nafs, وَنَعْلَمُ مَا تُوسْوِسُ بِهِ نَفْسُهُ «and We know what his soul whispers to him»
- Now we are told, yes, there is a nafs, there is an inner self, there is constant whisper happening in the wrong direction, but you have also been empowered with a heart

capable of reminder that is very powerful. So the response to the waswasa (whispering) is *لِمَنْ كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ* «for whoever has a heart», listening reinforce the heart who change as a result *أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ* «or who listens»

Section D

D1-Symmetrical structure of part 1 of the middle passage

- Then you come to the center of the surah, we are inside the heart of the Surah that is surrounded by 3 sections in the beginning A-B-C and followed by 3 sections in the end C-B-A
- Inside the earth of the surah there are 2 scenes:
 - One passage takes you from death all the way to judgment Day
 - Second passage contrast Hell with the life in Heaven
- The first ayaats of this passage depicts the fact that not a single word will remain unrecorded, and the last ayaah of this passage says the word will not be changed
- The second ayaah in the beginning, you were warned about the death and you have been heedless about all of this, now the covers have been removed and you can see. On the flip side, don't argue in front of me, the warning already came to you
- In the middle are the statements of the Qarin (devil friend that accompanied him on earth), on the one hand wants you to go to Hell and on the other hand there is another one that goes to Hell himself

Ayaat from the top	Question/Observation	Answer	Ayaat from the bottom
First	إِذْ يَتَلَقَّى الْمُتَلَقِّيَانِ عَنِ الْيَمِينِ وَعَنِ الشِّمَالِ قَعِيدٌ مَا يَلْفِظُ مِنْ قَوْلٍ إِلَّا لَدَيْهِ رَقِيبٌ عَتِيدٌ	مَا يُبَدِّلُ الْقَوْلُ لَدَيَّ وَمَا أَنَا بِظَلَّامٍ لِلْعَبِيدِ	First
Second	وَجَاءَتْ سَكْرَةُ الْمَوْتِ بِالْحَقِّ ذَلِكَ مَا كُنْتَ مِنْهُ تَحِيدُ	قَالَ لَا تَخْتَصِمُوا لَدَيَّ وَقَدْ قَدَّمْتُ إِلَيْكُمْ بِالْوَعِيدِ	Second
Third	وَقَالَ قَرِينُهُ هَذَا مَا لَدَيَّ عَتِيدٌ أَلْقِيَا فِي جَهَنَّمَ كُلَّ كَفَّارٍ عَنِيدٍ مَنَاعَ لِلْخَيْرِ مُعْتَدٍ مُّرِيبٍ الَّذِي جَعَلَ مَعَ اللَّهِ إِلَهًا آخَرَ فَأَلْقِيَاهُ فِي الْعَذَابِ الشَّدِيدِ	قَالَ قَرِينُهُ رَبَّنَا مَا أَطْغَيْتُهُ وَلَكِنْ كَانَ فِي ضَلَالٍ بَعِيدٍ	Third

D2-Symmetrical structure of part 2 of the middle passage

- This passage simply contrast Heaven and Hell. Hell asks « is there any more? » and Allah answers « We have more »

Ayaat from the top	Question/Observation	Answer	Ayaat from the bottom
<i>First</i>	يَوْمَ نَقُولُ لِجَهَنَّمَ هَلِ امْتَلَأَتْ وَتَقُولُ هَلْ مِنْ مَزِيدٍ	لَهُمْ مَا يَشَاءُونَ فِيهَا وَلَدَيْنَا مَزِيدٌ	<i>First</i>